Tangkhul tribes for this mission. 'Thinoselie, who had gone to China in November 1966, began his return journey in mid-January 1968. He brought with him more than 400 Chinese weapons, including a few mortars, machine guns, rocket launchers and wireless sets, mines and ammunition. Naga tribes living on the Burmese side of the border helped Thinoselie enter Nagaland.'[1]

The government and the Army HQ were livid with Eastern Command and 8 Mountain Division, in particular, for not being able to intercept and prevent this huge group of rebels from exfiltrating across the border into Burma, and thence to China. Neither were they able to catch Thinoselie's gang on its return. 'By April 1968 it had become clear that Mowu Angami and his gang were planning to return to Nagaland in the near future.'[2] Hence, 9 Maratha LI was moved from Phek to Kiphire near Tuensang. We reinforced the thin deployment of 8 Assam Rifles along the border, and were placed under the command of 162 Mountain Brigade commanded by Brigadier A.S. Vaidya, MVC. Some other battalions were also moved to plug the gaps in this border area.

The general officer commanding-in-chief (GOC-in-C) of the command was Lieutenant General Sam Manekshaw, and Major General N.C. Rawlley was our divisional commander. A warning was sent out down to the battalion level that the heads of the COs and the company commanders would roll in case the Chinese-trained gang managed to slip into Nagaland undetected this time. With the guillotine facing us there was tremendous tension in the air. Lieutenant General Manekshaw was looking at becoming the army chief and similarly, Major General Rawlley knew his future depended on the level of success that would be achieved by his division in neutralizing the infiltrating gang. Lieutenant Colonel K.L. Awasthy, our CO, also had a nagging suspicion that he might face the axe if we did not perform as expected or if the commanding general had his way, since he didn't appear to like his face! But we had a great team of youngsters like Baban Shinde, M.N.S. Thampi and D.B. Shekatkar, and we strove to ensure that the battalion or our CO was never let down. We built up strong bonds with the tribes of the border areas, like the Yimchungers, Noktes and